

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, lesser periwinkle grows in along roadsides and woodland borders. It is also cultivated as a garden plant. The leaves are gathered in spring.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Lesser periwinkle contains about 7% indole alkaloids (including vincamine, vincine, and vincamine), a bisindol alkaloid (vincarubine), and tannins. Vincamine increases blood flow and oxygen supply to the brain.

History & Folklore In his *Herbarium*, the 2nd-century CE Roman writer Apuleius describes lesser periwinkle's virtues "against the devil sickness and demoniacal possessions and against snakes and wild beasts." He also specifies the rituals used in harvesting the herb: "This wort thou shalt pluck thus, saying, 'I pray thee, *vinca pervinca*, thee that art to be had for thy many useful qualities... outfit me so that I be shielded and ever prosperous and undamaged by poisons and by water.' When thou shalt pluck this wort, thou shalt be clean of every uncleanness, and thou shalt pick it when the moon is nine nights old."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Lesser periwinkle is employed as an astringent and blood-staunching herb. Its astringency makes it a useful mouthwash for sore throats, gingivitis, and mouth ulcers. Its staunching ability is effective against internal bleeding, heavy menstrual bleeding, and nosebleeds. Since vincamine was discovered in the leaves, lesser periwinkle has been used to treat arteriosclerosis and for dementia due to insufficient blood flow to the brain.

Related Species Greater periwinkle (*V. major*) also has similar astringent activity. See also Madagascar periwinkle (*V. rosea*, following entry).

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Vinca rosea (Apocynaceae)

Madagascar Periwinkle

Description Fleshy perennial growing to 32 in (80 cm). Has glossy oval leaves and bright, white to red 5-petaled flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Thought to be a native of Madagascar, this herb is now common in many tropical and subtropical regions worldwide. It is cultivated commercially as a garden ornamental. The herb and root are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts, root.

Constituents Madagascar periwinkle contains over 70 different indole alkaloids, including vinblastine, vincristine, alstonine, ajmalicine, leurocristine, and reserpine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses This plant is used in folk medicine in the Philippines as a remedy for

diabetes. In the Caribbean, the flowers are used as a soothing eyewash.

Research Madagascar periwinkle's traditional use as a treatment for diabetes has led to extensive investigation into its properties. Vincristine and vinblastine are powerful anticancer agents, and are two of the most important medicinal compounds found in plants in the last 40 years. Vincristine is a standard treatment for Hodgkin's disease, and vinblastine for childhood leukemia. While extracts from Madagascar periwinkle have been shown to lower blood-sugar levels, simple preparations of the whole plant may not be effective.

Caution Take Madagascar periwinkle only under professional supervision.

Viola odorata (Violaceae)

Sweet Violet

Description Creeping perennial growing to 6 in (15 cm). Has toothed oval leaves, and attractive, violet-blue or white flowers with a 5-petaled corolla.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to much of Europe and Asia, sweet violet is a common wayside plant also found along roadsides and in woodlands. The flowers and leaves are collected in spring, the root in autumn.

Parts Used Flowers, leaves, root.

Constituents Sweet violet contains phenolic glycosides (including gaultherin), saponins (myrosin and violin), flavonoids, an alkaloid (odoratine), and mucilage.

History & Folklore In classical myth, sweet violet was associated with death, but classical physicians also knew it as an effective emetic and cough remedy. The 17th-century herbalist Nicholas Culpeper stated that: "All the violets are cold and moist while they are fresh and green, and are used to cool any heat or distemperature of the body either inwardly or outwardly."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sweet violet flowers and leaves have a gentle expectorant and demulcent action and they induce light sweating. They are often used as an infusion or syrup for treating coughs, chest colds and congestion. They are used in British herbalism to treat breast and stomach cancer. The root is a much stronger expectorant and, at higher doses, is emetic.

Research Iranian researchers investigated the use of two drops of sweet violet essential oil applied to the nostrils as a remedy for insomnia. The study, which lasted a month, found positive improvements in sleep measurements in those using the oil. A 2015 study of children with asthma concluded that sweet violet syrup helped to reduce symptoms of dry irritable cough.

Related Species The related dog violet (*V. canina*) has approximately the same uses as sweet violet. The Chinese *V. yedoensis* is prescribed

for hot swellings and tumors, mumps, and abscesses. See also heartsease (*V. tricolor*, following entry).

Viola tricolor (Violaceae)

Heartsease

Description Annual, biennial, or perennial plant growing to 15 in (38 cm). Has lobed, oval leaves and handsome violet, yellow, and white pansy-type flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Heartsease is native to Europe, North Africa, and temperate regions of Asia, and has become naturalized in the Americas. It thrives in many habitats, from grassy mountainous areas to coastal sites, and is also cultivated as a garden plant. The aerial parts are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Heartsease contains saponins, flavonoids, salicylates, mucilage, gums, and a resin.

History & Folklore K'Eogh wrote in his 1735 *Irish Herbal* that heartsease flowers "cure convulsions in children, cleanse the lungs and breast and are very good for fevers, internal inflammations and wounds."

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Western herbal medicine, heartsease is used as an anti-inflammatory and purifying herb and is taken for skin conditions such as eczema. An infusion also makes a useful wash for itchiness. Being expectorant, heartsease is used to treat bronchitis and whooping cough. The plant's established diuretic action makes it useful for treating rheumatism, cystitis, and difficulty in passing urine.

Research Recent research has found that heartsease has potential anticancer properties. It promoted programmed cell death (apoptosis) and inhibited blood vessel growth (angiogenesis), both important anticancer effects. A clinical trial in children with asthma found that heartsease syrup helped to control dry irritable cough alongside prescribed medication for asthma.

Self-help Use Hives, p. 303.



Heartsease grows wild in temperate areas, and is widely cultivated as a garden plant.